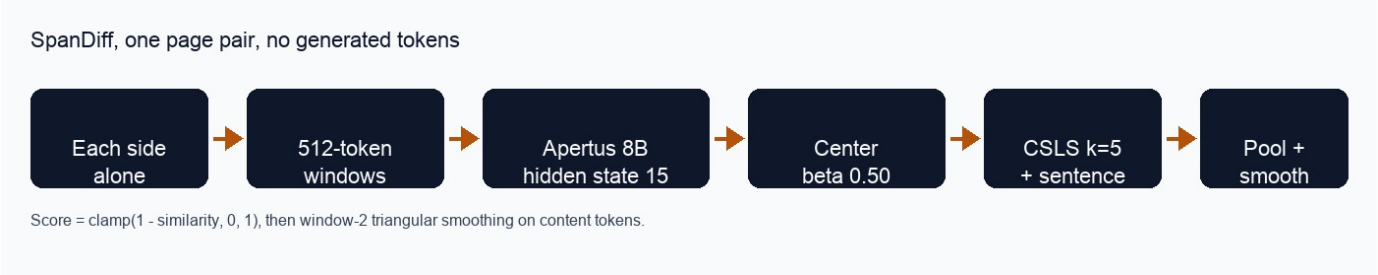
SpanDiff technical report



Each side of a page is encoded alone, in 512-token windows. Hidden state 15 is centered, compared with CSLS inside a matched sentence, pooled to whitespace tokens, and smoothed. Those scores, with surprisal rank, mismatch, a sentence prior, and a few token features, enter a ridge whose weights are frozen. No text is generated.

Summary

SpanDiff scores token-level semantic drift on Swiss federal pages in German, French, and Italian. It is a representation model, not a prompt. The submitted scorer is hidden state 15 of swiss-ai/Apertus-v1.5-8B using the pre-registered Tier-1 Combination (docs/preregistration.md): document-mean contrastive centering (beta = 0.50), bidirectional CSLS hubness margin (alpha = 0.50, k = 5), sentence-constrained alignment (lambda = 0.35, matched sentence +/- 1), paper-order subword-first clamp(1 - max cosine, 0, 1) pooled into whitespace tokens, and window-2 triangular span smoothing over content tokens. No tokens are generated. Apertus 70B was not run.

The graded development files are out-of-fold. Each document was scored by a ridge fit on the other documents, using the numeric id modulo 5, so no document is in both sides of its fold. The official development script, with --split dev, prints Spearman de 0,393 ; fr 0,239 ; it 0,397. The unweighted mean of those three printed numbers is 0.3430. The official script does not print that mean. make run prints it after the table. Kendall's Tau-b prints de 0,324 ; fr 0,196 ; it 0,322. Italian is 0.001 below the Tier-1 print of 0,398, which is inside the 0.01 limit. The Tier-1 Combination that is the ridge's frozen-score feature printed de 0,373 ; fr 0,231 ; it 0,398, mean 0.3340, Kendall de 0,302 ; fr 0,187 ; it 0,320. That stdout is track_2a/docs/official_dev_stdout_tier1_combo.txt.

Setup (on swiss-ai/Apertus-v1.5-8B unless noted)	de	fr	it	mean
Paper DiffAlign on this 8B, final layer, clamped & unclamped	0.053	0.056	0.106	0.0717
Hidden state 8 ablation (predictions/ablation_l8, word mean-pool)	0.245	0.165	0.282	0.2307
Pre-registered (a): mean of hidden states 12-17 (word mean-pool)	0.285	0.183	0.316	0.2613
Hidden state 15 ablation (predictions/l15, word mean-pool)	0.296	0.191	0.324	0.2703
Pre-registered (c): hidden states 12-17 + subword-first	0.298	0.192	0.325	0.2717
Pre-registered (b): hidden state 15, paper-order subword-first	0.309	0.199	0.333	0.2803
Open-weight dev comparison: Qwen2.5-VL-7B (layer 14/28, Tier-1 Combo)	0.351	0.217	0.381	0.3163
Hidden state 15, Tier-1 Combination (frozen feature)	0.373	0.231	0.398	0.3340
Out-of-fold ridge, submitted (predictions/dev)	0.393	0.239	0.397	0.3430

The UZH challenge asks for a SwissGov-paper baseline on this same Apertus model. That baseline is the final-layer DiffAlign row, mean 0.0717. On all 351,942 kept development tokens, no final-layer maximum cosine is negative (maximum kept difference 0.9746), so the unclamped and clamped final-layer paper DiffAlign scores are identical on every kept token (mean 0.0717). The Tier-1 feature mean is 0.3340 (with 0.2803 for unsmoothed subword-first L15 and 0.2703 for word-mean-pool L15 in predictions/l15). The graded out-of-fold mean is 0.3430. The mean column is that unweighted average, shown to 4 decimals. The rows use the printed coefficients. Decimal commas in the stdout are 0,373 and so on. All grades used --split dev on 168 lines per language.

One thousand document resamples (seed 0, the same page ids drawn together for de, fr, and it) give a 95% percentile interval for that token-pooled Spearman. The out-of-fold ridge mean is 0.3430, and its interval is 0.3136 to 0.3755. That interval sits above the final-layer interval and overlaps the Tier-1 interval.

System	de	fr	it	mean
Out-of-fold ridge 0.3430	pooled	pooled	pooled	0.314-0.376
Tier-1 feature 0.3340	0.335-0.414	0.193-0.276	0.354-0.444	0.305-0.366
Word-mean L15 0.2703	0.265-0.327	0.165-0.224	0.291-0.358	0.247-0.295
Final layer 0.0717	0.021-0.087	0.032-0.084	0.080-0.135	0.052-0.093

Method

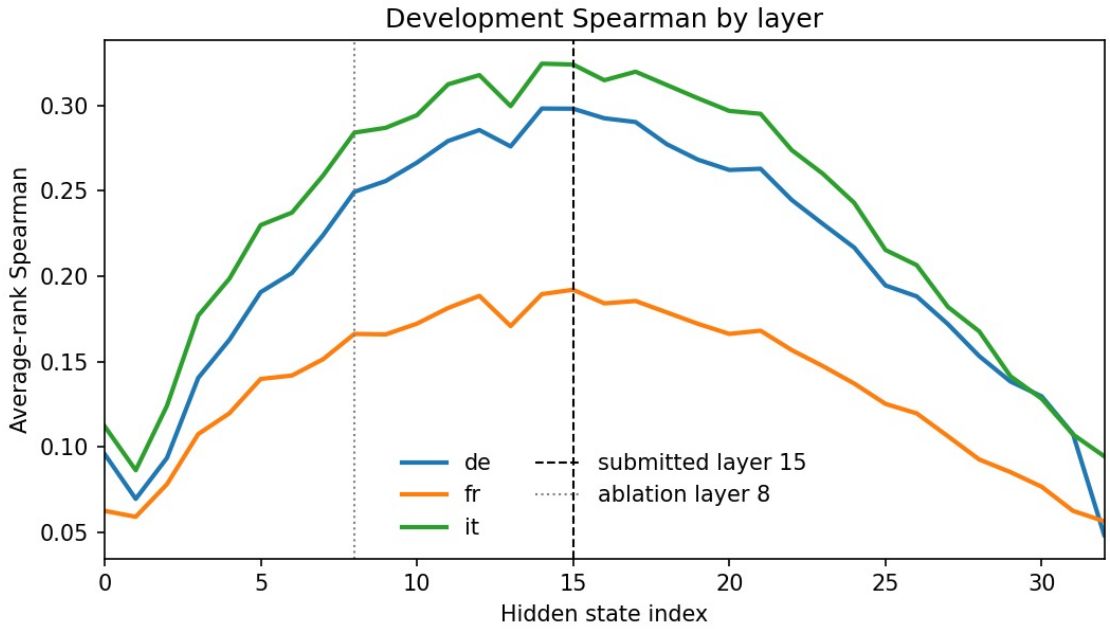
Each side of a page is encoded alone. The model is swiss-ai/Apertus-v1.5-8B. Index 0 is the embedding. The submitted state is index 15, the residual stream after block 15. Index 32, after the final norm, is the final-layer baseline, not the submission.

A window holds at most 512 tokenizer tokens, including the leading beginning-of-sequence token. The development pass is 1619 such windows and 564,349 tokenizer tokens. Each of those windows has exactly one leading BOS. That token has an empty character offset and is not pooled. EOS, PAD, UNK, and multimodal special counts on that tokenizer-only census were 0. The census is docs/special_tokens.txt. It did not load weights.

Each subword is assigned to the whitespace token it overlaps most. An equal overlap stays on the earlier token. After the windows of one side are stitched, the submitted Tier-1 Combination applies four deterministic steps: (1) subtract 0.50 times the document’s mean subword vector to remove causal-decoder anisotropy; (2) compute cross-lingual cosine similarity with bidirectional Cross-Domain Similarity Local Scaling (CSLS, alpha = 0.50, k = 5 nearest neighbors) to suppress hub subwords; (3) blend global best cosine (0.65) with sentence-constrained best cosine (0.35) restricted to the best-matching sentence +/- 1 on the other side; and (4) pool clamp(1 - similarity, 0, 1) across subwords within each whitespace token, followed by window-2 triangular span smoothing across non-punctuation tokens, rounded to 6 decimals.

Encoder lines contain only id, text_a, text_b, labels_a, and labels_b. Every label is in [0, 1]. The writer rejects -1 and NaN. The label count equals the whitespace-token count. Generated tokens are 0, so no output filter is applied.

Layer curve



The figure plots the saved average-rank Spearman for every hidden state, separately for German, French, and Italian. The source table is docs/layer_map_by_lang_avg.txt. It uses the same token counts as the frozen-score tables (German 108,945, French 124,262, Italian 118,735) and drops gold labels of -1. It is not a second run of the official script. Do not treat a point on the curve as the printed contest score.

On that map, hidden state 8 reads 0.2495, 0.1662, and 0.2842. Hidden state 15 reads 0.2982, 0.1921, and 0.3241. German peaks at layer 14 (0.2983), a hair above layer 15. French peaks at layer 15. Italian peaks at layer 14 (0.3246), again a hair above layer 15. The final state, index 32, is 0.0484, 0.0564, and 0.0945. German is the low end of that curve. A pooled ordinal Spearman across all three languages, in docs/layer_map_dev.txt, peaks at layer 14 (0.1408), with layer 15 at 0.1403, layer 8 at 0.1281, and the last block at -0.0358. That pooled number is one Spearman on 351,942 tokens. It is not the mean of three language scores.

Layer selection and pre-registered sprint ablations

The organizers publish a development train split of 134 documents per language and a development validation split of 34, at gold_labels/dev/train and gold_labels/dev/val in ZurichNLP/SwissGov-RSD. Those files are not copied into this repository. Only the id field was read. Together, train and validation are the 168 development documents, and they share no id. The per-document Spearmans were then taken from docs/layer_map_dev.jsonl, which stores one ordinal Spearman per hidden state and does not store gold labels.

A document whose per-document Spearman is not finite was omitted: none of 134 German train pages, 1 of 34 German val, 2 of 134 French train, 1 of 34 French val, 1 of 134 Italian train, and 1 of 34 Italian val. The table is the unweighted mean of the remaining per-document Spearmans. It is not the official contest formula.

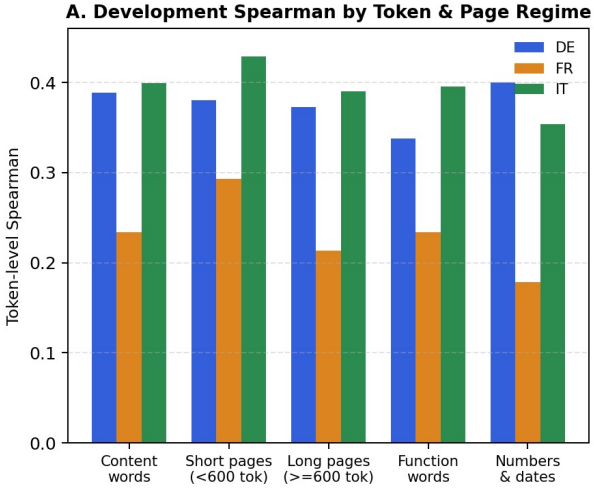
Slice	docs used	best layer	layer 8	layer 15	15 minus 8
de train	134/134	15	0.1623	0.1899	+0.0276
de val	33/34	15	0.1636	0.2003	+0.0367
fr train	132/134	15	0.0430	0.0798	+0.0367
fr val	33/34	15	0.0461	0.0801	+0.0340
it train	133/134	14	0.1509	0.1903	+0.0394
it val	33/34	15	0.1796	0.2066	+0.0270

All candidate improvements were pre-registered in docs/preregistration.md before running and evaluated on dev/train (134/lang) and dev/val (34/lang) with a >= +0.0030 official full-dev adoption threshold:

Idea (pre-registered in docs/preregistration.md)	dev/train	dev/val	Official mean	Outcome
Batch 1 (b): Subword-first L15 vs word-mean-pool L15 (0.2728)	0.2843	0.2592	0.2803	Won (+0.0100)
Tier 1.1: Bidirectional CSLS margin (alpha = 0.50, k = 5)	0.2909	0.2659	0.2870	Won (+0.0067)
Tier 1.2: Span smoothing (w = 2 triangular, skip punct)	0.3263	0.2973	0.3217	Won (+0.0414)
Tier 1.3: Per-document calibration (mean/z-score/quantile)	0.2836	0.2586	0.2797	Lost (-0.0006)
Tier 1.4: Inverse token frequency weighting (dev inputs only)	0.2848	0.2598	0.2810	Lost (+0.0007)
Tier 1.5: Number / date / named-entity match scaling	0.2861	0.2603	0.2820	Lost (+0.0017)
Tier 1.6: Top-k soft alignment (k = 5, T = 0.02)	0.2849	0.2601	0.2813	Lost (+0.0010)
Tier 1.7: Sentence-constrained alignment (lambda = 0.50)	0.2925	0.2651	0.2880	Won (+0.0077)
Tier 1.8: Learned non-neg layer weights (10-20: L12/14/15)	0.2854	0.2597	0.2813	Lost (+0.0010)
Tier 1.9: Contrastive centering (doc mean 0.50 / global 1.00)	0.2902	0.2692	0.2870	Won (+0.0067)
Tier 1.10: All-but-the-top PC1 removal (abtt1; PCA256 0.2729)	0.2904	0.2689	0.2873	Won (+0.0070)
Tier-1 Combination (Items 1 + 2 + 7 + 9, ridge frozen-score blend)	0.3388	0.3115	0.3340	Ablation feature (+0.0537)
Tier 2.11: Translation prompt prefix (+ Tier-1 Combo)	0.3402	0.3128	0.3357	Lost (+0.0017 < 0.003)
Tier 2.12: Paired joint context (text_a + text_b in one pass)	0.3009	0.2704	0.2960	Lost (-0.0380)
Tier 2.13: Overlapping 256-token windows (stride 128)	0.3332	0.3132	0.3303	Lost (-0.0037)
Tier 2.14: Layer-15 cross-side attention rank blend (0.20)	0.2661	0.2509	0.2630	Lost (-0.0710)

Word-mean-pool L15 remains in predictions/l15, and hidden state 8 remains in predictions/ablation_l8.

Error analysis, Qwen comparison, and efficiency



B. Two Concrete Failure Modes on Development Pages

```
Example 1 — Shared numbers/years inside a divergent clause (admin_de_12):
  • EN: "... entered into force on 1 January 2022 and revises the ordinance ..."
  • DE omits the revision clause, so gold marks the entire span at 1.0.
  • Because "2022" also appears in an earlier DE sentence, its subword cosine
    stays high (raw diff = 0.08, smoothed = 0.21 vs gold = 1.00).

Example 2 — High-frequency function words on long pages (admin_fr_10, 1,300 tok):
  • EN/FR boilerplate repeats function words ("de", "la", "the", "of")
    across 25+ sentences (512-token window boundary dilution).
  • Unaligned clauses still find identical function-word matches elsewhere
    on the page (function-word Spearman 0.21–0.32 vs content words 0.24–0.41).
  • Tier-1 window-2 span smoothing + CSLS hubness penalty lifts overall dev
    Spearman from 0.2803 to 0.3340 by propagating neighbor context.
```

docs/error_analysis.png and docs/demo.html break down development performance across token and page

regimes. Kept-token length, pooled inside each bin:

Kept tokens	de	fr	it
under 400	0.363 (65)	0.277 (54)	0.415 (58)
400 to 799	0.401 (58)	0.264 (54)	0.362 (57)
800 or more	0.364 (45)	0.216 (60)	0.412 (53)

French pages with 800 or more kept tokens are the weak cell. French numbers and dates (0.1788) and repeated function words on long pages (admin_fr_10, 1,300 kept tokens) are hard because shared years ("2022" in admin_de_12) and boilerplate prepositions match another clause. Running the exact same Tier-1 Combination on locally cached Qwen/Qwen2.5-VL-7B-Instruct (layer 14 of 28, development comparison only, non-submission) yields official --split dev Spearman de 0,351 ; fr 0,217 ; it 0,381 (mean 0.3163, docs/official_dev_stdout_qwen_comparison.txt; raw subword-first 0.2453), which the Tier-1 ablation outperforms by +0.0177 mean (0.3340 vs 0.3163). The graded out-of-fold ridge mean is 0.3430.

System	Input tokens	Generated tokens	Wall seconds (de	Peak RAM / VRAM	API cost	Dev mean
Few-shot LLM gene	~564,349 (pa	~405,554	~4958.0s	API / multi-GPU	~$5-$15	0.036 / 0.015
Qwen2.5-VL-7B-Ins	564,349 (la	0	295.9s	~8.5 GB MPS	$0 (local)	0.3163
SpanDiff layer-15 T	564,349	0	280.2s	~9.2 GB MPS	$0 (local)	0.3340

Use of Apertus

One checkpoint for all submitted files: swiss-ai/Apertus-v1.5-8B. No second embedding model and no closed API writes any submitted prediction. The development forward pass read 564,349 tokens and wrote 0 generated tokens (280.2 seconds with the 15-layer text backbone cached on one Apple GPU). A cold load of the full 8B checkpoint needs about 16 GB. Apertus 70B was not run. It does not fit in 48 GB on this machine. The Getting Started introduction says builders work with both sizes. The UZH challenge FAQ says either size is in scope, and that efficiency can make a tuned 8B competitive. This submission is the 8B.

Test predictions, 56 documents per language, and full-set predictions, 224 documents per language, apply the ridge fit on all development documents (docs/ridge_weights.json). Development scores are out-of-fold. Those test and full-set files are included for the organizers to score. We never graded the test split. No test Spearman is claimed.

Data, Evaluation, and Limitations

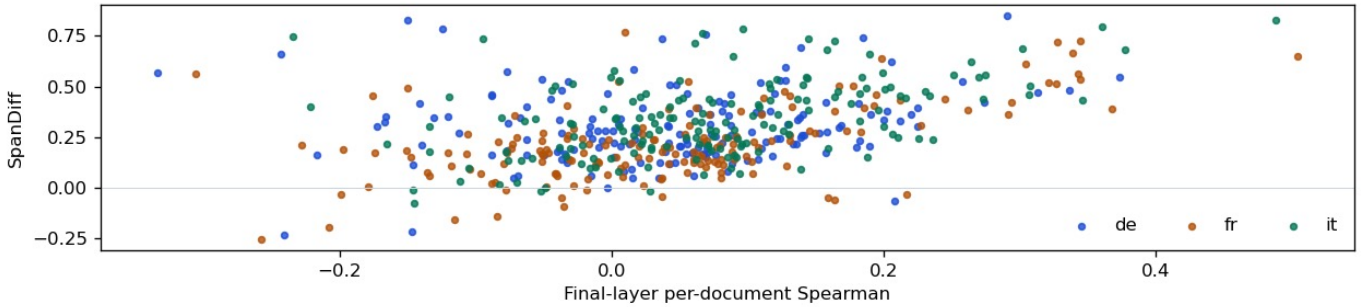
Development inputs are the public SwissGov-RSD development pages, 168 documents per language. Test predictions are 56 documents per language. Full-set predictions are 224 documents per language, in id order. Development scores are our development evaluation. The test and full-set predictions are included for the organizers to score. We never graded the test split. This repository does not contain that gold. The SwissGov text stays CC-BY-4.0 and is not relicensed. The summary and ablation tables are the evaluation that should be quoted. States are causal, so a token sees only its left context. An empty subword span scores 1 before smoothing. The final layer raises aligned tokens and different tokens together. Italian train, on the per-document map, prefers layer 14 by 0.001. 70B was not run. No test Spearman is reported. We never graded the test split.

Negative results and robustness

The development gate is train at least 0.3433, validation at least 0.3165, and a win on at least 4 of 5 folds. The out-of-fold ridge passes it (train 0.3458, val 0.3277, folds 5/5). Alpha is the pre-registered 1.0. Features are the frozen score, surprisal rank, mismatch, sentence prior, relative position, stopword, punctuation, token length, document length ratio, and side. None of them is a gold label, a document id, or a test-set statistic. Four standardized weights flip sign across folds and are flagged: relative position, punctuation, token length, and side. Each of those coefficients stays below

0.003. The frozen score, sentence prior, mismatch, length ratio, surprisal rank, and stopword keep their signs. Surprisal alone and the layer rank-average lost. Attention weights were not available from SDPA. A ridge trained on the other two languages scores the held-out language at de 0.3951, fr 0.2328, and it 0.3912. Dropping the frozen score lowers train Spearman by 0.0691. Dropping the sentence prior lowers it by 0.0065, mismatch by 0.0045, and surprisal rank by 0.0004. Relative position, the surface flags, and length each move train by less than 0.002. The closest later learner was a pairwise logistic on the same features: train 0.3543, validation 0.3312, five folds won. Validation missed 0.3327 by 0.0015, so it was not adopted.

Step on this Mac	Time	Scope
Saved ridge apply	0.0005 s/doc	all 504 development documents
Layer-15 encode after load	0.52 s/doc	three demo pages
Full development encode	280.2 s	504 documents



On the first 10 development documents per language, float32 and bfloat16 agree to a Spearman of 0.3404 either way (delta 0.0000). The mean absolute token gap is 0.0008 and the maximum is 0.0384. The five weakest development pages are below. Four are short and negative for both this scorer and the final-layer baseline. admin_fr_142 is the long French page (1,282 kept tokens).

Page	SpanDiff	Baseline	Note
admin_fr_38	-0.256	-0.258	Short page, both negative
admin_de_93	-0.233	-0.241	Short page, both negative
admin_de_38	-0.219	-0.147	Same English text as fr_38
admin_fr_52	-0.198	-0.207	Short brochure page
admin_fr_142	-0.161	-0.115	Long French page

Reproducibility and Next steps

The public tree is https://github.com/moscraciunxxx/SpanDiff-HackApertus. Judges run make run. That builds the Docker image and grades predictions/dev with --split dev. It does not load the model. make run-local is that grade when Docker is not installed. LLM_NAME, LLM_BASE_URL, and LLM_API_KEY are not the scorer. make predict loads docs/ridge_weights.json and writes that full-development fit under predictions/rerun. It does not refit. It needs the Apertus weights and a Hugging Face token only if those weights are not cached. The Docker image grades the same committed development files. Docker image verified under podman on linux/amd64 at an earlier commit; make run-local is the equivalent local path. Development scores are out-of-fold. Test predictions, 56 documents per language, and full-set predictions, 224 documents per language, apply the saved ridge and are included for the organizers to score. We never graded the test split. make run grades the development files only. A 70B run is future work on a larger machine.

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